
CRESTED GECKO

Correlophus ciliatus



Beginner

Complete Care Package

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BeastlyFacts

Practical care guides for curious animal lovers

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How to Use This Package

This package is a practical owner manual, not a textbook. Read the Quick Profile and Care Guide once to understand the setup. Then use the checklists, temperature and humidity targets, and symptom reference as working tools.

It is written for beginners who want clear standards without fluff. It is not a substitute for a reptile-experienced veterinarian. If your gecko shows red-flag symptoms, use the symptom table as a triage aid and contact a vet.

Best use: print the high-action pages and keep the rest as your offline reference.

Print these first

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Quick rule: a reliable wet-dry humidity cycle, a working humid hide, and consistent CGD prevent most beginner problems.

1. Quick Profile

The crested gecko (*Correlophus ciliatus*) is native to the tropical rainforest canopy of New Caledonia and was thought extinct until rediscovered in 1994. It is an arboreal, crepuscular gecko with specialized toe pads (setae) and a prehensile tail. Adults reach 7-9 inches and 35-55 grams. They thrive in a daily wet-dry humidity cycle and do not require supplemental heat in most homes. Tails do not regenerate if dropped. Captive lifespan is typically 15-20 years. IUCN status: Vulnerable.

Native Range	New Caledonia (Grande Terre, Isle of Pines)
Natural Habitat	Tropical rainforest canopy and understory
Adult Size	7-9 in (18-23 cm); 35-55 g
Wild Diet	Fruit, nectar, pollen, small invertebrates
Captive Diet	CGD + insects 1-2x weekly
Typical Lifespan	15-20+ years with good care
Difficulty	Beginner
Conservation	Vulnerable (IUCN)

Fun Facts

- Thought extinct until rediscovered in 1994; now one of the most popular pet lizards worldwide.
 - No eyelids - they lick their eyes clean with their tongue.
 - Each foot has roughly 500,000 microscopic setae that stick via van der Waals forces.
 - Tails do not regenerate. A tailless adult (frogbutt) is otherwise healthy and common in the wild.
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Cost Overview

A proper one-time setup typically runs \$300-600 before the gecko. That covers a front-opening vertical enclosure (18x18x24 or larger), substrate, low-output UVB, hygrometer, thermometer, climbing structure, plants, and an initial vet exam with fecal. Ongoing costs usually fall between \$20 and \$30 per month for CGD powder, occasional insects, and supplements. Normal morphs cost about \$50-200; rare morphs can reach \$500-1,000+. Itemized ranges appear with the Shopping List.

2. Full Care Guide

Housing & Enclosure

Minimum 18x18x24 inch front-opening enclosure for one adult. Taller is better - 18x18x36 or a 2x2x2 foot upgrade is common. Vertical height matters more than floor space because they are arboreal. Front-opening glass or PVC holds humidity better and reduces stress; reaching from above mimics a predator.

Hatchlings under about 12-13 grams do better in a smaller grow-out enclosure before moving to the adult setup. Bioactive setups with live plants (pothos, bromeliads, ficus pumila), leaf litter, and a clean-up crew of isopods and springtails work well and help hold humidity.

Never house two adult males together. Do not group hatchlings - they bite each other's tails, which will not grow back. House adults singly unless you are an experienced keeper carefully monitoring weight and aggression.



Example crested gecko enclosure setup

Temperature, Humidity & Lighting

Most homes stay in the ideal range without supplemental heat. Daytime ambient 72-80°F is ideal. Night drops into the mid-to-upper 60s are fine. **Never** allow temperatures above 85°F anywhere in the enclosure - prolonged exposure risks fatal heat stroke. Temperatures at or below about 72°F for extended periods cause lethargy and dropped appetite.

Humidity must cycle daily. Mist in the evening so surfaces and plants are wet (spike toward 80-100%), then allow the enclosure to dry toward 40-50% (or 50-70%) by the next afternoon. Constant high humidity without a drying period encourages respiratory issues and mold. A digital probe hygrometer mid-enclosure is required.

Low-output UVB (T5 HO 5.0 or equivalent, UVI about 1.0-2.0 at the basking area) on a 10-12 hour photoperiod is recommended even though complete CGD already supplies D3. It supports natural pathways and better long-term bone health. Skip colored night bulbs entirely.

Substrate & Furnishings

Hatchlings and quarantine: paper towel. Adults: coconut fiber, sphagnum, or a bioactive soil mix at least 2 inches deep. Spot-clean daily. Full substrate change monthly for simple setups, every 3-4 months for bioactive.

Provide dense climbing: cork bark tubes, sturdy branches, and vines at multiple heights. Live or artificial plants for cover. A humid hide lined with damp sphagnum moss is essential for clean sheds. Shallow water and feeding dishes complete the basics.

Handling

Wait about two weeks after arrival for the gecko to acclimate and start eating normally before any handling. Geckos under about 10 grams are too fragile for routine handling. Begin regular sessions once the gecko is a sub-adult or older juvenile (roughly 8-15 grams, 4-5 inches, about 6 months old).

Let the gecko walk onto your hand rather than grabbing it. Use treadmill: cup your free hand in front as it reaches the edge so it hops hand to hand on its own. Stay low over a soft surface - they jump readily and a fall onto hard floor can injure them. Evening sessions are best. Start with 1-2 minute sessions every other day and build toward about 15 minutes. Keep total daily handling under about 20 minutes.

Never grab, restrain, or touch the tail under any circumstances - tail loss is permanent. End the session immediately if you see tail-wagging, squeaking, erratic jumping, gaping, closed eyes, or active fleeing.

Diet & Feeding

Commercial crested gecko diet (CGD) such as Pangea or Repashy is the foundation. Mix with water to a ketchup-like consistency and offer in a shallow raised dish every other day for adults (daily for young juveniles). Refresh within 24-48 hours. Rotate flavors to reduce pickiness.

Live feeder insects (crickets, dubia nymphs, small hornworms) 1-2 times per week add enrichment and variety but are not strictly required if CGD is complete. Prey size: no wider than the space between the gecko's eyes. Gut-load 24-48 hours. Dust with calcium with D3 2-3 times per week if UVB is limited, or primarily plain calcium if low-level UVB is present; multivitamin about once weekly.

Fresh water in a shallow dish; they also drink from misted leaves. Occasional fruit purees (mango, banana) are treats only - never a replacement for CGD.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- **Never** keep humidity constantly high without a daily drying period.
- **Never** allow temperatures above 85°F for extended periods.
- **Never** grab or restrain by the tail.
- **Never** skip a humid hide - stuck shed on toes is the most common preventable injury.
- **Never** house two adult males together, or group hatchlings.
- **Never** use prey larger than the space between the gecko's eyes.
- **Never** rely on a heat lamp as primary climate control in a typical home.

Enrichment

Crested geckos are arboreal jumpers. The highest-impact enrichment is a complex vertical climbing network: cork bark backgrounds, cork tubes (preferred daytime sleeping sites), sturdy branches at mixed angles, and flexible vines that create crossing routes. Leave intentional open gaps - they jump well and use the space.

Dense foliage (pothos, philodendron, bromeliads, ficus pumila) and multiple elevated hides reduce daytime stress. Magnetic feeding ledges keep food in the arboreal zone. Scatter or hide small amounts of CGD and offer live insects 1-2 times weekly so the gecko must search and stalk. A bioactive setup with tropical springtails and dwarf isopods adds continuous low-level stimulation but is not required for basic welfare.

House singly (or carefully matched females only). Rearrange climbing structures only occasionally - sudden total overhauls stress shy individuals. Always secure branches so they cannot collapse under the gecko's weight or during jumps.

3. Health & Common Issues

Most crested gecko problems are husbandry-driven and preventable. Stuck shed, metabolic bone disease, and respiratory issues track directly to humidity cycling, calcium/D3, and temperature. Weigh weekly on a gram scale - weight change is often the earliest warning sign. Schedule a vet visit within the first 30 days and annually with a fecal exam.

Red Flags - Act Early

Contact an exotic veterinarian promptly if you observe any of the following. Bring a clear photo of the enclosure, recent temperature and humidity readings, current diet and supplements, and recent weights.

- Soft or misshapen jaw, tremors, floppy limbs, or kinked spine (possible MBD).
 - Stuck shed remaining on toes after 24 hours of improved humidity.
 - No bowel movement for a week, bloated abdomen, or straining (possible impaction).
 - Open-mouth breathing, mucus, or wheezing (respiratory infection).
 - Ongoing weight loss, lethargy, or sustained loss of appetite.
 - Temperatures above 85°F or a gecko that cannot move away from heat.
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Stuck Shed (Dysecdysis)

Most often affects toes, tail tip, or eyes and can cut off circulation. Caused by humidity problems. Prevent with the daily wet-dry cycle and a dedicated humid hide. If shed sticks, soak 10-15 minutes in shallow lukewarm water and gently work with a damp cotton swab. **Never** force dry shed. Severe cases can cost a digit.

Metabolic Bone Disease (MBD)

From chronic calcium or vitamin D3 deficiency. Early sign: soft or rubbery lower jaw. Advanced: floppy or weak limbs, misaligned jaw, kinked spine, tremors, difficulty climbing. Some damage is permanent. Prevent with complete CGD, proper dusting, and low-level UVB. Diagnose via bloodwork and x-rays - see a vet at the first soft-jaw sign.

Floppy Tail Syndrome (FTS)

Tail hangs limply or at an odd angle when the gecko rests upside down on glass. Associated with chronic upside-down resting and sometimes calcium or pelvic issues. Overlaps with MBD risk but is not diagnostic on its own. Usually irreversible and often benign once calcium is corrected.

What to do

- Review calcium schedule and UVB if used
- Reduce constant upside-down resting by improving hides and structure
- See a vet to rule out deeper metabolic or spinal issues

What not to do

- Never assume FTS is only cosmetic without checking calcium/husbandry
-

Impaction

Blockage from loose substrate, prey too large, or undigested shed. Signs: no bowel movement for a week or more, bloated abdomen, straining, lethargy, appetite loss.

What to do

- Paper towel substrate for young geckos; prey no larger than the eye-span gap
- Mild cases: 15-minute warm soak; reassess climate
- Persistent cases: vet within 24-48 hours

What not to do

- Never use fine loose substrate with hatchlings
 - Never wait a week on a bloated, straining juvenile
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Respiratory Infection & Tail Loss

Respiratory infection tracks to enclosure too cold or constantly too wet. Signs: open-mouth breathing, mucus, wheezing, lethargy.

What to do

- Correct cold spots and force a real day dry-down
- See a vet promptly - this is not wait-and-see

Tail loss

Autotomy is a stress or defensive response. The tail does not regenerate. A frogbutt gecko climbs, eats, and breeds normally. Prevention is gentle handling and stable husbandry.

4. Quick Reference & Checklist

Essential Setup Checklist

- 18x18x24 inch (or larger) front-opening arboreal enclosure
- Coconut fiber, sphagnum, or bioactive substrate (paper towel for hatchlings)
- Low-output UVB (T5 HO 5.0 or equivalent) on a 10-12 hour timer
- Digital thermometer and probe hygrometer
- Commercial crested gecko diet (Pangea, Repashy, or similar)
- Feeder insects + gut-load + calcium with/without D3 + multivitamin
- Cork bark tubes, branches, and plants for climbing
- Humid hide with damp sphagnum moss
- Misting bottle or automatic mister
- Shallow water and feeding dishes
- Gram scale for weekly weighing

Temperature & Climate Targets

Zone	Target	Notes
Daytime ambient	72-80°F	Most homes need no supplemental heat
Night drop	65-72°F	Natural and healthy
Hard maximum	85°F	Prolonged exposure above is dangerous
Humidity (evening spike)	80-100%	After misting; surfaces wet
Humidity (day dry-down)	40-50%	Must dry; constant wet is a problem
UVB	T5 HO 5.0	UVI ~1.0-2.0; 10-12 hr photoperiod

Why these targets: Crested geckos come from mild tropical forests in New Caledonia. They tolerate cool better than heat. The daily wet-dry cycle supports clean sheds without encouraging respiratory infection or mold.

Emergency & Quick Targets - Crested Gecko

Print this page and keep it near the enclosure. When something looks wrong, start here.

Quick Targets

Parameter	Target
Day ambient	72-80°F
Night drop	65-72°F
Hard max	85°F - never higher
Humidity spike	80-100% after evening mist
Humidity dry-down	40-50% by next afternoon
UVB	Low-output T5 HO 5.0, 10-12 hr

Red Flags - Act Early

- Soft or misshapen jaw, tremors, floppy limbs (MBD)
- Stuck shed on toes after 24h of corrected humidity
- No stool 7+ days, bloated, straining (impaction)
- Open-mouth breathing, mucus, wheezing
- Ongoing weight loss or sustained appetite loss
- Temps above 85°F with no cool retreat

Do This Now

- Move to correct temp/humidity immediately
- Photograph enclosure + animal; note recent weights
- Contact exotic vet - bring husbandry notes

5. Owner Tools & Decision Guides

Budget & Shopping List

Prices vary by region and whether you buy new or used. A solid beginner setup without designer morphs typically lands in the \$300-600 range before the animal. Annual ongoing after setup is roughly \$235-430.

Shopping checklist

- Front-opening vertical enclosure 18x18x24+
- Substrate (coconut fiber, sphagnum, or bioactive mix)
- Low-output UVB fixture and bulb (T5 HO 5.0 range)
- Digital probe hygrometer + thermometer
- CGD powder (multiple flavors helpful)
- Insect feeders + calcium (with and without D3) + multivitamin
- Cork bark, branches, live or silk plants
- Humid hide materials (sphagnum moss, cork)
- Misting system or quality spray bottle
- Shallow feeding and water dishes
- Gram scale

Approximate Price Ranges

Item	Range
Gecko (normal morph)	\$50 - \$200
Enclosure 18x18x24 vertical	\$150 - \$200
Low-output UVB fixture + bulb	\$50 - \$80
Decor, hides, climbing	\$45 - \$80
Thermometer + hygrometer	\$15 - \$25
Initial vet exam + fecal	\$65 - \$210
Ongoing monthly	\$20 - \$30

First 30 Days Checklist

- Set up enclosure and stabilize the temperature/humidity cycle for several days before the gecko arrives
 - Introduce the gecko and minimize handling for the first two weeks while it starts eating normally
 - Establish CGD feeding every other day (daily for young juveniles) and begin weekly weighing
 - Confirm the first shed goes smoothly with the humidity routine and humid hide
 - Schedule an exotic vet visit with fecal exam within the first 30 days
 - Begin short, calm handling sessions only after acclimation and once the gecko is above ~10 grams
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Symptom Quick Reference

Sign	Possible Cause	Action
Stuck shed on toes	Low humidity / no humid hide	Improve cycle; soak 10-15 min
Soft jaw / tremors	Possible MBD	Review diet + UVB; see vet
No stool 7+ days / bloated	Possible impaction	Warm soak; vet if persists
Open-mouth breathing	Respiratory / too wet or cold	Correct climate; vet promptly
Floppy tail on glass	FTS / calcium imbalance	Review calcium; vet check
Tail dropped	Stress or defensive drop	No treatment; permanent
Ongoing weight loss	Multiple causes	Check temps, diet, then vet

Daily & Weekly Routine

Print this page and keep it near the enclosure. Consistency matters more than perfection.

Daily

- Visual check: eyes, toes, grip, energy, breathing
 - Confirm temperature is in range (72-80°F day)
 - Mist in the evening if humidity has dropped; allow daytime dry-down
 - Offer fresh CGD on schedule (every other day adults; daily for young juveniles) and remove old
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Weekly

- Offer dusted feeder insects 1-2 times
 - Spot-clean substrate, dishes, and high-contact surfaces
 - Check plants, cork, and climbing security
 - Weigh on a gram scale and log it
 - Confirm humid hide is still damp enough for sheds
-

Every 6-12 Months

- Replace UVB bulb on calendar - do not wait for visible dimming
- Annual wellness visit + fecal with a reptile-experienced vet
- Rotate CGD flavors; reassess enclosure size and climbing density

Last changed / logged dates (write in):

UVB bulb replaced: _____ Next due: _____

Last vet visit: _____ Last weight: _____

Owner Log - Crested Gecko

Track weight and basic daily notes. Weight change is often the earliest warning sign. Print extra copies as needed.

Weight & Daily Log

Date	Weight (g)	Ate?	Shed?	Notes

Humidity Troubleshooting

- Stuck shed or dry toes → increase evening mist duration; verify humid hide is damp; confirm day dry-down still happens.
- Respiratory signs + wet enclosure → force a stronger dry-down; reduce mist volume; check ventilation; see vet if breathing is labored.
- Mold / fungus smell → substrate too wet continuously; full spot-clean; improve airflow; shorten mist.
- Gecko avoids open areas → add elevated hides and foliage; reduce handling; check temps are not high.

Enrichment Checklist - Crested Gecko

Enrichment is not optional decoration. Use this as a setup and monthly review checklist.

Setup & Ongoing Checklist

- Complex vertical cork + branch network with intentional jump gaps
 - Multiple elevated daytime hides (cork tubes preferred)
 - Dense foliage at multiple heights
 - Magnetic / elevated feeding ledge (not floor-only)
 - Live insects 1-2x weekly for hunting
 - Scatter or tuck small amounts of CGD among ledges
 - Occasional small rearrange only - never total overhaul
 - All branches secured against collapse
-

Monthly review notes (write in):

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Rule: stability for core hides/heat/water systems; novelty only in non-critical items.

Glossary

Bioactive - Enclosure with live plants and clean-up crew organisms that help maintain the environment.

CGD - Crested Gecko Diet - powdered complete formula that forms the base of the diet.

Crepuscular - Most active at dawn and dusk.

Dysecdysis - Abnormal or incomplete shedding.

Frogbutt - Crested gecko that has permanently lost its tail.

FTS - Floppy Tail Syndrome - tail hangs limply when resting upside down; often linked to calcium imbalance.

Humid hide - Enclosed moist retreat used to support clean sheds.

MBD - Metabolic Bone Disease from calcium or vitamin D3 deficiency.

Setae - Microscopic hair-like structures on toe pads that enable climbing on smooth surfaces.

Treadmilling - Handling method where the gecko walks hand to hand rather than being grabbed.

This care package was compiled from BeastlyFacts research and practical husbandry standards.

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Disclaimer: This package is for educational purposes and is not a substitute for veterinary care. Husbandry standards evolve; always verify critical health decisions with a qualified exotic/aquatic veterinarian.

No external links are included in this document.
